

MINDSET

Cultivating Optimism

Optimism is not a personality type you are born with or without. It is a way of reading events, and ways of reading can be trained, like any other skill.

Time: about 30 minutes**Level:** moderate**You need:** a pen and one honest memory

WHY BOTHER

Eight things optimism quietly gives you

1 Resilience

Setbacks feel temporary and workable, not permanent and hopeless.

2 Better health habits

Optimists tend to look after themselves more, stress less and recover better.

3 Stronger relationships

You notice the good in people, and they feel it.

4 Higher achievement

Optimism fuels the motivation and persistence big goals demand.

5 Life satisfaction

A hopeful outlook goes hand in hand with a happier day to day.

6 Better problem-solving

If you believe a fix exists, you actually go and look for it.

7 Longer life

Some research links an optimistic outlook to a longer lifespan.

8 Less helplessness

Optimism gives you back a sense of control when things get hard.

Rooted in the learned optimism work of Martin Seligman (2006), reworked here as a coaching exercise.

THE CORE DIFFERENCE

What makes an **optimist**?

Mostly it is how you explain bad events to yourself. Three things, called the 3 P's, decide whether a setback shrinks or takes over. Notice which way you lean.

01**Permanence**

Pessimist: "It will always be like this."

Optimist: "This is a rough patch, and it will pass."

02**Pervasiveness**

Pessimist: "Everything is going wrong."

Optimist: "That one thing went wrong. The rest is fine."

03**Personalisation**

Pessimist: "It is my fault, I am the problem."

Optimist: "Several things played a part, and I did my bit."

NOT THE SAME AS TOXIC POSITIVITY

Toxic positivity insists everything is fine, ignores the hard stuff and sets expectations that deny reality. Real optimism is nothing like that. Sometimes things are not fine, and that is okay. This exercise is about seeing through your gloomiest thinking habits so you end up with a more **balanced** view, not a fake one.

TRY IT NOW, 30 SECONDS

Think of the last thing that went wrong. Finish these three sentences out loud.

"It will _____ forever."

"It affects _____ of my life."

"It is _____ my fault."

— THE ABCDE MODEL

Five steps to rewrite a bad moment

Martin Seligman's ABCDE model walks you from the knock itself to a better way of carrying it. Pick a recent setback and work through the letters in order.

**Adversity**

Name the situation that rattled you. Just the facts: what happened, where, who.

**Beliefs**

Catch the thoughts and assumptions that fired up. What did you tell yourself about it?

**Consequences**

See what those beliefs did. How did they change your feelings, actions and outlook?

**Disputation**

Cross-examine the belief. Is it accurate? Is it helpful? What does the evidence say, and what else could be true?

**Energisation**

Notice the lift when you shift. Enjoy it, mark it, and use it as fuel for next time.

— PICK YOUR SETBACK

Choose something real but not the heaviest thing in your life. A tough conversation, a wobble at work, a plan that fell through. Start small and build the skill.

Name _____

Date _____



STEP 1

Adversity: what happened?

01 What was the exact event that set off the bad feeling or thought?

02 When and where did it happen, and who was there?

03 How did it hit you in the moment?

04 How is it still affecting you now?

B

STEP 2

Beliefs: what did you tell yourself?

01 What was the very first thought that crossed your mind?

02 What did you start believing about yourself, other people, or the situation?

03 Does anything from your past feed these beliefs?

04 What was the tone of your inner voice? (harsh, fearful, critical, defeated...)

C

STEP 3

Consequences: what did those beliefs do?

01 How did those beliefs shape your feelings and your behaviour right then?

02 What effect did your reaction have on the situation and the people in it?

D

STEP 4

Disputation: argue with the belief

01 What evidence supports your belief? What evidence goes against it?

02 What other explanations might you have missed?

03 How would someone with a different outlook read the same situation?

04 What would you tell a good friend who believed the same thing?

05 Is this belief moving you forward, or holding you back? How?

E

STEP 5

Energisation: notice the shift

01 How do you feel now that you have challenged the belief?

02 What new, more balanced belief could you take on instead?

03 How will it change the way you handle a similar knock next time?

04 What can you do to keep that new belief alive?

05 How will you reward yourself for shifting your view?

REPEAT IT

Do this once a week with a small setback. After a month the disputing starts happening on its own. That is the skill landing. If a belief feels too heavy to argue with alone, bring it to a session.